



# **DECK# Annotation Guide**

**How to physically prepare your DECK# deck**

Version: 1

# Table of contents

- What you need ..... 1
- Before you begin ..... 2
- Preparation: sorting the deck ..... 3
- Phase 1 – Quadrant markers (back) ..... 3
- Phase 2 – Connectivity markers (edges) ..... 4
- Phase 3 – Orientation dot (north pole) ..... 5
- Phase 4 – Primary glyphs and modifiers ..... 5
- Exception: Jokers ..... 6
- Summary chart per card ..... 7
- How to read the annotation matrix ..... 7

## What you need

- A standard French-suited playing card deck (52 cards + 2 Jokers)
- A fine-tip black permanent marker
- A fine-tip red permanent marker
- The annotation matrix (section 13 of the specification, or the `decksharp_matrix.csv` file)

Estimated time: 15–20 minutes.

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# Before you begin

The DECK# deck is annotated **once**, before any play session. Annotations are permanent. There is no in-game annotation: variable states are managed with physical tokens (dice, tokens, coins).

Each card receives four types of annotation, in distinct zones:

| Annotation                   | Zone                             | Tool                     |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------|--------------------------|
| Quadrant markers             | Back                             | Black marker             |
| Connectivity markers         | Physical edges (front face)      | Black marker             |
| Orientation dot (north pole) | SE corner (front face)           | Black marker             |
| Primary glyph + modifier     | S/N and NE/SW zones (front face) | Black or red (see below) |

**Color rule:** glyph color is always contrasting relative to the card's suit. - Red cards (♥ ♦) → glyphs in **black** - Black cards (♣ ♠) → glyphs in **red**

Glyph color is not a choice: it is automatically derived from suit.

## Preparation: sorting the deck

Separate the deck into three groups:

1. **Red cards** (♥ ♦) — 26 cards
2. **Black cards** (♣ ♠) — 26 cards
3. **Jokers** — 2 cards, set aside

Work first on **red cards**: they require only the black marker for all annotation. Then proceed to **black cards**: they require a tool switch only in the final phase (glyphs in red). Handle **Jokers** last — they have minimal, separate annotation.

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## Phase 1 — Quadrant markers (back)

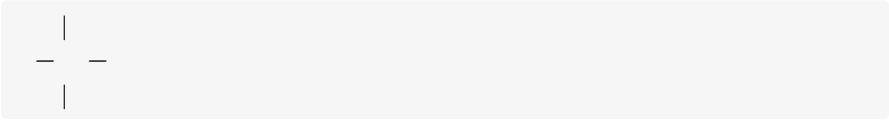
**Tool:** black marker.

With cards oriented face-down, draw quadrant markers on all 54 cards (red + black + Jokers).

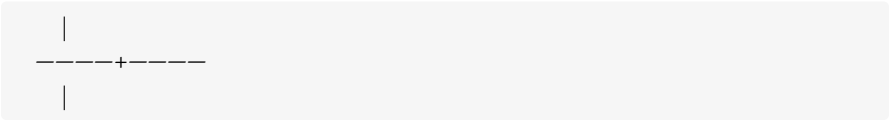
Quadrant markers are identical on all cards and indicate the center and sides of the card to the player when it is placed face-down on the table. Choose one of the two variants and keep it consistent throughout the deck:

**Minimal variant** — four short segments starting from the midpoint of each edge toward the center, without crossing it:

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**Extended variant** — full cross from edge to edge:



Allow the ink to dry before flipping the cards.



## Phase 2 — Connectivity markers (edges)

**Tool:** black marker.

Consult the annotation matrix. For each card, the **Connectivity** column indicates which edges are **open** (connected). Edges not listed receive a **wall marker**: a thick line drawn along the external white margin of the card (~3–4 mm), on the front face.

**Example:** if the matrix shows N+W, the North and West edges are open — leave them unmarked. The South and East edges receive the wall marker.

Allow a few seconds of drying time between cards before stacking them.



## Phase 3 — Orientation dot (north pole)

**Tool:** black marker.

Draw a small dot • in the far lower right corner of each card — the **SE** zone of the front face. This dot breaks the vertical symmetry of standard cards and indicates the north pole: the side with the pre-printed index at top left (NW).

The dot goes on all 52 standard cards and both Jokers.

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## Phase 4 — Primary glyphs and modifiers

**Tool:** black marker for red cards (♥ ♦) · red marker for black cards (♣ ♠).

Consult the annotation matrix. For each card, annotate:

- **Primary glyph** in the **S** zone (lower middle edge, inside the card) and its rotated mirror in the **N** zone (upper middle edge).
- **Modifier glyph** in the **NE** corner (upper right corner) and its rotated mirror in the **SW** zone (lower left corner).

The mirror positions (N and SW) make the card readable in a fan, regardless of orientation in hand.

The DECK# vocabulary comprises seven glyphs:

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| Glyph      | How to draw it          |
|------------|-------------------------|
| • dot      | a single dot            |
| — line     | a horizontal line       |
| + cross    | two perpendicular lines |
| × diagonal | two diagonal lines      |
| △ triangle | three strokes           |
| ○ circle   | a closed ring           |
| □ square   | four strokes            |

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## Exception: Jokers

The two Jokers receive the **quadrant marker** on the back (Phase 1, identical to the 52 standard cards) and the **orientation dot** in the SE zone (Phase 3). No connectivity markers, no primary glyph, no modifier.

They are uninstantiated variables: each game decides whether and how to use them.

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# Summary chart per card

| Element              | Position                 | 52              | standard cards | 2 Jokers |
|----------------------|--------------------------|-----------------|----------------|----------|
| Quadrant markers     | Back                     |                 | ✓              | ✓        |
| Connectivity markers | Front face edges         | ✓ (from matrix) |                | —        |
| North pole dot       | SE corner front face     |                 | ✓              | ✓        |
| Primary glyph        | S + N zones front face   | ✓ (from matrix) |                | —        |
| Modifier glyph       | NE + SW zones front face | ✓ (from matrix) |                | —        |

## How to read the annotation matrix

The matrix lists all 54 cards with three pieces of information:

- **Connectivity:** open edges, in N/S/E/W notation separated by +. Edges not listed receive the wall marker.
- **Primary:** the glyph to draw in the S zone (and its mirror in N).
- **Modifier:** the glyph to draw in the NE zone (and its mirror in SW).

Glyph color is not in the matrix because it is always derived from suit: black for ♥/♦, red for ♣/♠.

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DECK#

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